THE NOBULOUS SET · GAME TWO

Designed by Jonathan Weeks

Nobulous Apprenticeship Program (NAP)

A prestigious opportunity. Terms and conditions apply.

One Apprentice, three Time Slots a day, and a workload that does not care how tired you are. Earn Credits across four subjects, survive the things that go wrong, and pass a Final Exam assembled from the subjects you actually studied.

COMPONENTS

- 3 double-sided Apprentice cards — 6 Apprentices, one to a side
- 26 Task cards
- 6 Opportunity cards
- 6 Setback cards
- 3 Time Slot cards — Morning, Afternoon, Evening
- 3 Following in Nobulous' Footsteps (FINF) cards
- 12 Final Exam cards
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the 3 stat dice — HP, STR, REC — and the Chip

SETUP

1. Choose an Apprentice. All six begin at **2 HP / 2 STR / 2 REC**; they differ only in abilities.
2. Choose a difficulty level: **Easy 5**, **Standard 6**, **Hard 7** or **Nobulous 8** Credits.
3. Shuffle in **your difficulty's Setbacks** — 3, 3, 4 or 5 of the 6, from the *Difficulty* table below — with the 26 Tasks and 6 Opportunities to form the **Assignment deck**. Return the unused Setbacks to the box.
4. Choose a FINF setting: **Increase 1–3** or **Reduce 1–3**. Standard is **Reduce 1**. Take that many of the 3 FINF cards at random; return the rest to the box. See *Following in Nobulous' Footsteps* below for what each direction does.
5. Set aside the 12 Final Exams. You will build the exam pool later.
6. Place the color selection side of the chip next to the Morning Time Slot card.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

The Final Exam comes either way. You sit for it when you reach your **Credit goal** — see the difficulty table — or when the Assignment deck runs out, whichever happens first. Credits are earned by completing Credit Tasks; not satisfying the Credit goal does not end the game, it costs you dice (see *Leaving the apprenticeship*). Regardless, you must survive three exams with at least 1 Health remaining to win.

DIFFICULTY

Difficulty can be adjusted in two principal ways: the **Credit goal** you must reach before the Final Exam, and the number of **Setbacks** shuffled into the Assignment deck. Choose a level before you start the game.

LEVEL	CREDIT GOAL	SETBACKS
Easy	5 Credits	3
Standard	**6 Credits**	**3**
Hard	7 Credits	4
Nobulous	8 Credits	5

FOLLOWING IN NOBULOUS' FOOTSTEPS (FINF)

FINF is a second dial, independent of the difficulty level, that works in two directions. Choose one setting before you start and keep it for the whole game.

Increase — 1 / 2 / 3

Take that many FINF cards at random and **shuffle them into the Assignment deck**. When one is drawn, **add an Assignment from the top of the deck to the corresponding Time Slot** then discard the FINF card. Ignore Skulls on Assignments added by FINF, and never exceed 4 Assignments in one row.

Reduce — 1 / 2 / 3

Take that many FINF cards at random, flip them face-up, and set them to the side. Each can be used once. You may **remove a non-Final-Exam card from the active Time Slot** only if you hold the FINF card numbered for that slot: spend it, exhaust all dice stored on the removed card, and turn the FINF card face-down. Holding FINF 2, for example, lets you remove one card during an Afternoon.

FINF cards are not used during the Final Exam, in either direction.

SUBJECT ICONS

Task and Final Exam cards use these icons to identify their subject. A Task with no subject icon is unmarked.

ICON	SUBJECT
	Anatomy
	Engineering
	Procedure
	Theory

HOW THE APPRENTICESHIP ENDS

Play until you **reach your Credit goal** or **the Assignment deck runs out**, then proceed to the Final Exam.

The Final Exam begins at the end of a Day, never part-way through one. Reaching your Credit goal early does not interrupt the Day: play out the Time Slots that are left, resolve the End of Day, and then set up the Final Exam. A goal reached in a Morning still requires an Afternoon and an Evening session. Completing additional goals during these additional time slots is helpful — each Credit above your goal allows you to recover another die in *Preparation* for the Final Exam.

Running out of Assignments is the exception and ends the apprenticeship immediately. With no deck there is nothing to reveal, so the remaining Time Slots cannot be played.

If your Health ever reaches 0 you lose immediately — during the apprenticeship or during the exams.

THE DAY

Each day has three Time Slots: **Morning**, **Afternoon**, **Evening**. Each slot follows these steps below. Note, REC only occurs at the end of the day. Dice can only be recovered during the day via the **Special Recovery** or from card-specific effects.

1. Perform **Special Recovery** for the color on the dial (Day 1 Morning has nothing queued, so there is none.)
2. Reveal 2 Assignments and place one into the row as your **Primary** assignment (shift unresolved cards to the right); **Discard the other Assignment.** The Primary's recovery-color dot sets the color queued for the next Time Slot.
   - If a Setback is revealed, you **must** take it. If two Setbacks are revealed, take the one with the higher Target.
   - If you take a card with one or more **Skulls**, add the corresponding number of cards from the Assignment deck to the Time Slot (if able). See the *Skulls* box below.
3. Attempt to complete Assignments with Strategy rolls.
4. Rotate or discard unresolved Assignments as described below and exhaust non-stored committed dice. Then, set the dial to the Primary's dot and advance the chip to the next Time Slot. **Do not recover again** — the dial you have just set is what the next slot will recover during step 1.

After Evening, resolve **End of Day**.

Assignments placed in a given Time Slot stay there until completed or discarded; they do not follow you into the next Time Slot. A Time Slot can hold a maximum of **4** Assignments — if the row is already full when you reveal, discard both revealed cards and take nothing. **The queued recovery color does not change** when that happens: with no Primary to set a new one, the dial stays where it is and the next Time Slot recovers on the same color again.

SPECIAL RECOVERY

Recover **all** exhausted dice of the queued recovery color.

STR in NAP

STR is the number of **Strategy rolls** available in a Time Slot; it resets for every Time Slot. **It does not cap how many Assignments you may complete.** One roll's successes can be spread across several Assignments, and cards already holding stored progress can finish alongside them. Clearing more Assignments than you have Strategy rolls is normal — it is what storing progress is *for*.

ATTEMPTING ASSIGNMENTS

- You may assign dice across as many Assignments as you like (in the active Time Slot) during a roll.
- **Required Effort:** Choose at least one Assignment — a Setback if one is present — and commit either one die matching that Assignment's color dot, Red, or at least two dice of another color. **This requirement can be waived only if no legal commitment/assignment is possible.**
- To **complete an Assignment or store progress on it**, the successes you apply must include a die matching its color dot, Red (as wild), or two successful dice of another color. After this requirement is satisfied, you may add successes for any additional committed dice to the card.

Unresolved Assignments

- Successful dice on an unresolved Assignment may be **stored as progress** instead of being exhausted.
- **At the end of the Time Slot**, every unresolved Task flips to its **Demand** side — a harsher printed effect, and sometimes a higher Target. **10 of the 26 Tasks** print a Demand Target 1 above their Request; the other 16 print the same number on both faces. Flipping costs nothing by itself.
- An unresolved Opportunity rotates **180 degrees** for one final chance. It **survives the End of Day in between** and gets that chance in the same Time Slot on the following day. **You cannot store progress on Opportunities**. If the rotated Opportunity is still incomplete at the end of the day, discard it without applying an effect or penalty.
- An Assignment that is *already* on its Demand side and still unresolved at the end of a Time Slot **inflicts its printed Demand penalty** and is then discarded. When a penalty exhausts dice, exhaust dice of that Assignment's **recovery-dot color** first; otherwise, exhaust your weakest dice.

- Once the next Time Slot begins, stored dice are locked to that Assignment and cannot be voluntarily exhausted.
- When an Assignment finally resolves, its committed and stored dice exhaust unless the card says otherwise. A Credit Task completed on its **Demand** side still counts as a completed Credit.
- **Both faces pay.** A Task completed on either side resolves the completion reward printed on *that* face. Each Task pays **at most once** — a card finished as a Request never pays its Demand reward, and the reverse.
- Rotate every completed Task, Opportunity, or Setback **90 degrees** and leave it in its Time Slot until End of Day. Resolve its completion reward before continuing.
- Completing an Opportunity never pays out on the spot: you **keep the card as a coupon** (see *Completed Opportunities*).

RESOLVING A COMPLETION REWARD

Exhaust the completed Assignment's dice first, then resolve its reward — before your next Strategy roll.
A reward that names a color ("recover 1 Green die") takes **any** exhausted die of that color, including one the card has just exhausted. If no die of that color is exhausted, skip that recovery; nothing is substituted. A reward that names two colors pays both independently.

Resolve a card's reward **once**. If the reward manipulates the Assignment deck, use the cards that remain. Finish resolving a reward before checking whether an empty deck has ended the apprenticeship.

Assignment types

TYPE	ROLE
Task	The only source of Credits.
Setback	Mandatory and disruptive. No Credits.
Opportunity	Optional. No Credits or penalties; rotate once for a final chance. Completing one earns a coupon.

SETBACKS

All six print the same two rules and differ only in Target: **clear this before working other Assignments here**, and **at the start of this Time Slot, if this Setback has no stored dice, exhaust 1 available die**. Clearing one reopens the row.
The exhaustion check happens at the **start of a slot** with the Setback already present and no dice stored on it. A Setback revealed after that check has passed makes its first check on a later visit to its slot.

Completed Opportunities

An Opportunity pays nothing when you complete it. Instead you **keep the card in front of you as a coupon**. It has no expiration: spend it whenever you like, on any Day, including during the Final Exam. Each is a **one-time use** — spend it, apply the effect, then discard the card. Every coupon prints **when** it may be spent, before or after a roll; that window is part of the card.

OPPORTUNITY	SPEND IT TO…
Take an Unauthorized Break	Cancel 1 Health loss, whenever one would happen.
Raid the Supply Closet	*Before rolling:* recover up to 2 dice of one non-Red color.
Borrow Better Instruments	*After rolling:* reroll 1 die and keep the new result.
Study Nobulous' Notes	*Before rolling:* flip one unresolved Demand in this Time Slot back to its Request side. In an exam, reduce that exam's Target by 2 instead.
Salvage Useful Components	*After rolling:* add 1 Green die as a Crit to an Assignment here or to this exam.
Practice on a Spare Brain	*After rolling:* count one rolled Crit as 3 successes.

Rerolling with Borrow Better Instruments **does not use a Strategy roll**. Practice on a Spare Brain needs a Crit that is still a Crit: apply any printed restriction that reprices it first, and a Crit a card has reduced to a single hit is not eligible. Rewards that add a die still obey the color rule — the Assignment must already hold a legal die. You may hold any number of coupons; unspent ones score nothing.

Study Nobulous' Notes is a genuine reset. The Demand keeps its stored dice and progress and follows the normal flip rule again at the end of the slot. If the progress already on the card meets the lower Request Target, the Task completes at once: exhaust its dice and pay its **Request** reward.

ADDING A DIE THROUGH A REWARD

Two effects put a die onto a card without rolling it — **Sharpen the Surgical Implements** (1 Yellow die as a hit) and **Salvage Useful Components** (1 Green die as a Crit).
Use an **available** die, or one committed on the current roll whose result you have not yet applied or exhausted. Set it to the stated result and place it on the receiving card: it supplies its printed color and counts once. A die already applied, stored or exhausted is not eligible.

Sharpen's receiving Task must already hold stored progress that satisfies the color rule. Salvage obeys the receiving card's printed restrictions, including any that reprice a Crit. Store the added die if the Assignment is still unresolved and allows storage; if the Assignment completes, exhaust it with the rest before taking the reward. Resolve both effects before exhausting the roll's unused dice.

Six rewards that need a ruling

CARD	HOW IT RESOLVES
Align the Memory Probes	The additional Strategy roll **raises this slot's roll allowance by one**, even if STR is already spent. Pay out every card the current roll completed before taking it.
Prepare the Transplant Rig	The chosen color **overrides the Primary's dot** for the next Special Recovery, and carries into *Preparation* if that recovery is the next one.
Test the Cerebral Coupler	Optional, and you must have **2 exhausted dice of the chosen die's color** before you pay the available die.
Document the Procedure	Move one Setback to a slot with room. It counts toward that row's 4-card limit, its restriction applies there, and the move triggers no start-of-slot effect. It may be moved into the active row, where it restricts your later rolls. A Setback locking the active row must be cleared before you can work this Task at all — so this plans around a *future* Setback.
Dispose of Failed Samples	Discard one **other** unresolved Demand Task in the active slot. Exhaust its stored dice; it pays no penalty and earns no Credit.
Update Nobulous' Lab Notes	Take any Assignment that was passed over at a reveal or discarded unresolved. A retrieved Task returns as a **fresh Request** — reset any rotation or last-chance status — and the normal reveal, Setback and Skull rules apply when it comes up again. Completed cards stay in the discard and cannot be taken, including spent Opportunities.

SKULLS

Skulls resolve only on Assignments *you chose*. Ignore Skulls on cards added by another Skull, by FINF, or by a forced replacement. If a Skull would add an Assignment while the Time Slot already holds 4, do not add a card — instead rotate the Skull-generating Assignment to its Demand side once. Further blocked Skulls do nothing.

END OF DAY

Move all completed Assignments from the Time Slots to the face-up discard pile. Reveal and discard the top card of the Assignment deck. Ignore all of its text, effects and Skulls. Then recover exhausted dice equal to your **REC**.

THE FINAL EXAM

Leaving the apprenticeship

Discard unresolved Assignments and exhaust their stored dice. If you are short of your Credit goal, exhaust 1 available die per missing Credit in the order Red, Purple, Blue, Green, Yellow, looping as needed.

Preparation

- Recover 1 exhausted die.
- Recover 1 further exhausted die per Credit *above* your Credit goal. You may not pick the same color twice.
- Perform the queued Morning special recovery.

Building the Final Exam pool

Randomly select **1 Final Exam card from each subject** — Anatomy, Engineering, Procedure and Theory. Include every subject, even one you earned no Credits in. Shuffle the 4 selected cards and draw **3** Final Exams to sit; set the unused card aside.

Each subject therefore has a **75% chance** to appear and can appear at most once. Credits no longer decide which exams you sit — they only reduce Targets, below. Use this same draw in the NRJ campaign.

Resolving the exams

1. Reduce the exam's base Target by 1 for each Credit you hold in that subject.
2. Roll against the modified Target, honoring the exam's printed restriction.
3. **Lose 1 Health for each success below the modified Target.** If you still have Health, you passed.
4. Perform Special Recovery using that exam card's own color dot, then resolve the next exam.

All three exams are mandatory. FINF is not used during the Final Exam. Finish all three with at least 1 Health to win NAP.

CARRYING NAP FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign (Tier III).

NAP contributes **6 Devious Opportunities**. Any of these opportunities completed during the apprenticeship, regardless of whether the reward is used, has the potential to be retained for the *Imposter Scenario*; you may only keep a maximum of 3 Devious Opportunities (your choice). A retained card reduces a **Knowledge** Exhibit's Target in the *Imposter Scenario* by **2**.